

Counting the Cost to Finish Your Tower

Open again to Luke 14. We will be looking at this chapter again. Are you ready?

Let us begin with verse 11, passing in review:

For whosoever exalteth himself shall be abased; and he that humbleth himself shall be exalted.

I am glad this includes you and me: whosoever.

In reality, this eleventh verse is the subject of the entire chapter. What we learned last week is that it is talking about exaltation that comes to a man in the kingdom of God. Whoever humbles himself shall be exalted. Whoever exalts himself shall be abased.

If there is anything I want to learn this side of glory from my heavenly Father, it is to understand how His exaltation comes. I understand how men's exaltation comes. For many years, what I did not understand was how His exaltation comes.

When Jesus comes and puts His hand on you and says, "Friend, come up higher," there is not a thing this side of hell the devil can do about it. You and I are coming up higher.

This verse is talking about how exaltation comes to a man in the kingdom. In fact, Jesus dedicated the rest of the chapter to understanding how that exaltation comes.

What is going to be different about these sessions is that God charged me to teach on perseverance. If I have to go over something fifty-five times, I am going to go over it fifty-five times. At this point I do not care about the eloquence with which I deliver the Word. I do not care what I look like when I am doing it. I do not care if I appear to you to be a babbling idiot because I repeated it for the forty-ninth time.

I am going to keep going until one of two things happens: He releases me, or you get it.

That is the mark of a teacher. The mark of a good teacher is not how much information he handles in volume. The mark of a good teacher is whether he is able to transport into your spirit the image God has put into his. I do not mean merely to the degree that you say, "Oh yes, I get it." I mean to the degree that you not only understand it, but the inspiration arrives with it, charging you by the anointing of God to do something about it.

If Jesus dedicated the rest of this chapter to exaltation that comes to a man in the kingdom, then I want to know what He said about it. If we camp in this chapter long enough, we are going to understand what He said about you being exalted in His kingdom.

I would like Jesus to come and say, "How would you like Me to exalt you? How would this group like to be exalted into a place in Me where you can cause revival?"

I like that.

I have belonged to intercessory groups, and we have never really seen revival. Listen to me: there is a place in Him, a place of exaltation, where He can use you and me to bring revival. I do not care how many prayer groups have been taken out before revival came. There is a place in Him.

When we start talking about sweat, perseverance, untold hours in confrontation with the devil, and nobody coming along to pat you on the back and tell you what a good job you are doing, we are talking about why prayer groups fail.

We are always going to thin and purge before we establish and grow. To be quite frank with you, by the second month I expected this to be down to six or seven people. Congratulations on hanging in there. I have been trying to run you off.

This chapter is talking about exaltation that comes to a man in the kingdom. If I humble myself, I will be exalted. If you humble yourself, you will be exalted. Jesus said, "Whosoever."

Then the question is: what is the God-ordained principle for humbling myself?

The world's way does not work. We have tried to pass the world's way on to the church. It does not work.

"If you scrub the toilets, vacuum the carpets, stack the chairs, and dust them, one day God will come along and exalt you to the top."

There is much to be said for faithfulness and hard work, but you can still be scrubbing that toilet thirty years from now. You might as well know, if you do not suspect it by now, that the humbling God is talking about has something to do with His Word and His kingdom.

Luke 14:11 says:

For whosoever exalteth himself shall be abased; and he that humbleth himself shall be exalted.

Then verse 12 says:

Then said he also to him that bade him, When thou makest a dinner or a supper, call not thy friends, nor thy brethren, neither thy kinsmen, nor thy rich neighbours; lest they also bid thee again, and a recompence be made thee.

Since we have established that He is talking about exaltation in the kingdom, He is beginning to lay out a teaching by which you and I can understand exaltation.

He says that when you make a supper, do not call your friends, brothers, kinsmen, and rich neighbors, because they will simply invite you back and pay you back for what you did for them.

If we are talking about exaltation in the kingdom, then He is saying, "What is the motivation of your heart?"

If you invite your neighbors and rich kinsmen because they can recompense you, what is your motivation? Is it self-exaltation?

What is your motivation for giving?

I have been in it long enough to know. What do you give for? The most quoted verse is Luke 6:38:

Give, and it shall be given unto you.

We like to emphasize the "unto you" part. After all, if we are going to receive an offering, we want you to give well. So we have developed a whole message based on what you will get back. If I can promise you enough, you will give more.

But notice what Jesus said. We are talking about exaltation that comes in the kingdom. He asks, "Why do you invite your neighbors and rich kinsmen? Is it so they will recompense you? Is it so the services you rendered will be paid back? Is your motivation for giving your own self-exaltation?"

We are going somewhere. If you want His exaltation, then listen, because there is only one way it is going to come: through humbling yourself.

Verse 13 says:

But when thou makest a feast, call the poor, the maimed, the lame, the blind:
And thou shalt be blessed; for they cannot recompense thee: for thou shalt be recompensed at the resurrection of the just.

This supper is the one God prepared for the world through the Lord Jesus Christ. The call going to the world is, "Come and eat from the table prepared by God through the Lord Jesus Christ."

At that table the poor do not have to be poor anymore. The halt do not have to be diseased anymore. The blind do not have to be blind anymore. God has prepared these things through the table of the Lord Jesus Christ, and we are bidding people to come and eat.

Notice His exaltation. The exaltation He is talking about cannot be given by the world. It is the ability to say, "Poor, come and eat from the table of the Lord Jesus Christ. Blind, you do not have to be blind anymore." From God's exaltation, He will deliver you the power to serve with.

But notice the motivation. He says to invite the poor, the halt, the maimed, the lame, and the blind, and you will be recompensed at the resurrection of the just.

One problem the church has had through the generations is that we have been unable to get our eyes off the problem and onto the answer.

Thank God, faith has done much for us in this area:

I am not moved by what I see, hear, or feel. I am only moved by what I believe. I take the Word of God as the final say-so in my life.

Consequently, because we have learned how to take the Word of God and live in victory here, we faith people have probably done less teaching about heaven than any group that ever came up and yelled revival.

The old holiness people used to write songs about heaven, preach about heaven, and talk about heaven all the time. Many of their songs centered around that glorious place waiting for us and the great homecoming. The holiness and Pentecostal revivals, and those great healing meetings in the 1930s and 1940s, majored a lot on heaven.

One of the greatest tricks the devil pulls on us is getting us so wrapped up in this temporary life--believing God for the needs and cares of this life--until we have an implosion. He tries to keep you from ever fastening your operation on heaven, laying up treasures there, and knowing that when you work on earth to lay treasures up in heaven, God turns around and works a reward here.

Jesus said, "Invite the poor, the halt, the maimed, the lame, and the blind. Your reward shall be great. You will be recompensed at the resurrection of the just."

If God can turn you to know that your reward is laid up in heaven, that revelation will cause you to labor more violently and fervently here. When you lay treasures up in heaven, it releases God in your life here and now.

If you ever had a revelation of heaven, you would have trouble staying here. I do not mind anymore. In fact, I have never been so strong.

I have sat by the bedside of enough people and watched them die clutching their Bibles until their knuckles were white, playing tapes and confessing the Word, until finally the saints and others involved had to say, "We do not understand it. They died. They knew the Word, and we cannot tell that they were doing anything wrong, but God must have had a reason."

That kind of thing shakes a person's confidence. People think, "That was a godly woman, or a godly man. If they died, then if something comes on me, what chance do I have?"

It instills fear.

The Lord began dealing with me. He said that when I see a person clutching the Bible in fear, dying while their knuckles turn white, I need to start instilling in them a vision of heaven.

There is a reason. Nobody ever died of a disease Jesus redeemed you from. If you are a believer, He has redeemed you from disease. If you are a believer, He has redeemed you from poverty. But one of the primary killers is fear, usually the fear of death itself.

Most of us procrastinate so hard because we were not born with a sense of an end. In fact, you are going to live forever, whether in hell or heaven. The only question is where you will spend eternity.

We were not born with the sense of an end. That is why death is so foreign to me. I look in the mirror and say, "Dad? Dad, is that you?"

No, it is me.

I am looking out of the same eyes I looked out of when I was eighteen. Something in me will not even relinquish its hold on the thought that there is no end.

Death is feared because everything seems so final.

They called me to the bedside of a little girl who had been dead for six hours. She was about five years old. With everything in me, everything I knew how to draw out, I gave it a fight. I laid my hands on her. I did everything except jerk her up like Smith Wigglesworth, hold her against the wall, and say, "Walk." I came close.

There she was, that little body lying there. It was not God's will for her to die, no way, shape, or form.

You say, "Why? Surely the child went to heaven."

Sure. But let me tell you what that child lost. Jesus said there is recompense at the resurrection of the just. That child went home with no reward. She is happy, but the reward of her earthly course was lost. That child gave it up involuntarily.

A lot of you give up your reward simply because you are too lazy to get up and do something about it.

Death seems so final because the emotions around you go crazy. Mama is sobbing. You have to close the door behind you and say, "God, all right. We have to close the chapter on this one. It is over. I do not know what else to do." The doctors cannot even get the mother to let go of her baby and leave the room. It hurts.

We are born with a sense of eternal life. Eternity is working in us. In our spirit there is no sense of an end. Our thinking will never fully correlate with death because there is no end. When you see death in the natural realm, it throws everything into confusion.

The devil uses death like almost nothing else to instill fear, because it is the fear of the unknown. No disease has ever killed a believer apart from the fear the devil uses. Fear will kill.

The Lord said, "Instill a vision of heaven on the inside of them."

It took Him a while to get the information about heaven over to me. He told me, "If you can eradicate their fears and their fear of death, you are dealing with torment and worry, which are the opposite of love. He that is made perfect in love has no fear. Perfect love casts out fear because fear has torment."

If you can zero in on the torment and fear, you zero in on the handle the devil is killing them with. It is not the disease; it is the fear.

When you start talking about heaven, it can look as if you are saying, "We all give up. You are going to die."

No. I am after the fear. If you can get a revelation of that place, nine times out of ten Jesus will turn to you and say, "You just opened the door to healing. You do not have any more fear. Satan lost his hold over you. Now you are going to have to stay here and finish your job, because I need you in the kingdom. There are many things I need done. You are not cut short on your reward yet, so get back out there and get busy praying."

Think about heaven for a moment.

All the babies who die go there, even the aborted babies. At the moment of conception, that little spirit springs into life through the law of Genesis: go forth and replenish the earth. God instilled that in us, and it is an awesome responsibility.

You are not in the animal class. You are in the God class. When you bring forth that little offspring, you have brought forth an eternal creature who will spend forever in eternity, in one place or another. That is an awesome responsibility.

Aborted babies go to heaven and finish growing up, but they are cheated out of their reward. They grow up in heaven. There is an incredible nursery there. Angels run around with babies on their hips. You mothers and grandmothers who love babies and donated your lives to nurseries because you could not quit putting your lips all over those little babies--can you imagine a baby's nightmare? Big lips hovering over the crib, coming at them continually.

The angels and the saints of God who love children's ministries help raise these babies. The nurseries are full of them. These little ones grow up, and when new arrivals come to heaven from earth, these children like to sit down and have you tell them stories about how it is here. Pain, misery, and lack are foreign concepts to them.

In heaven there is no corruption and no decay. Not only is there no lack; there is not even a sense of lack.

There are trees where you can reach up and pick one of twelve kinds of fruit. Twelve different manners of fruit grow on every tree. You can sit under a tree, reach up, grab a fruit, and eat it; a month later that particular fruit grows back.

The saints wander around the hills of paradise and the mountains. They come into the holy city, where the streets really are made of gold. A river flows out of the throne. It is liquid refreshment, liquid power. When you cup your hands, reach down, and drink, it refreshes you like going out under the power in a good service, when your mouth cannot quit talking about it because the presence of God is heavy on you.

Fountains spring up all over heaven. The saints have things they do, but there are great worship meetings in heaven. You can gather with the saints and start talking about the good things of heaven. The presence of God so indwells every ounce of heaven that before long your hands are in the air, you are on your knees, saying, "Glory to God. Praise God. Hallelujah."

Every one of you has an angel assigned to you. He has been with you all your life.

The moment you step out of your body, it is nothing to be afraid of. Have you ever loaded a wood stove with long gloves that go up to your elbows? You can stick your hands into the fire and load the wood. When you are done, you peel the gloves off. It is as simple as that.

One moment you are lying there, and the next moment you are sitting up, getting out of your body. You look back, and the first thing you wonder is, "My God, what was I afraid of? This is okay."

If you are not finished with your course and your reward on this earth, then the hardest time Jesus has is making you come back. You are over the dying thing. You wonder what you were afraid of. There is no misery, no pain, no sense of lack.

Jesus says, "Yes, and you are not done. If you stay here now, this is it. Your reward is finished. You are not done yet."

"But it is so nice here."

"Yes, but you should go back."

"But I want to stay."

"There are saints praying you back."

"I do not want to go back."

"But you must."

Then you go back and sit up in your body.

Folks, when people who die are not quite right, you do the same thing: thank God for His grace.

If there is one thing this prayer center is not designed to do, it is to bring you under condemnation. I am going to preach a heap of responsibility, but along with that responsibility will come a heap of reward.

When God began to engraft the love of God into me, I had tried to understand love in times past and had come up with something plastic.

I knew I was supposed to love my neighbor as myself. I knew I was supposed to show forth the love of God, because by this will men know that I represent the kingdom, the gospel, and the love of God. I knew I was supposed to take hardship and portray tremendous love toward people.

But it was a stereophonic, plastic operation: "Yes, yes, I know what I am supposed to do."

Because we had been taught about the love of God all our lives, we tagged love as an attitude or an emotion. Then I found out that torment and fear are the opposite of love. God could talk to me.

He said, "My love is not merely an emotion or attitude. My love is the opposite of fear and torment. It is the absolutes of peace."

You can reach down inside yourself and measure the love of God that is working in you at this moment. Reach inside and feel for the unsettling peace. That means you have so much peace that the devil could pour hell out on you and threaten you with poverty, disease, starvation, and hardship, and you would say, "I laugh in your direction, devil. I snicker at you."

That is the love of God working through a man: absolute peace so strong that you could stand where you are, intercede for ten years, and pray revival down on Tulsa while the devil gathers all his forces from the four corners of the earth and throws them at you. He cannot destroy you, because you say, "I have the thing working in me that never fails: the love of God, the peace that surpasses all understanding."

You are not going to have that until you get your eyes, mind, and reward off what you can get out of this life.

Jesus said to call the poor, halt, maimed, lame, and blind, and that you will be recompensed at the resurrection of the just. Because of the resurrection, we become less centered on the temporary.

We become short-sighted when we get caught up in persecutions, afflictions, and cares until we have an implosion. Everything that heads our direction caves in on us, and we become the center of our problem. Everything revolves around us: the prosperity of this life, pride, exaltation, and things that have to do with this life.

As long as those things are the center, you are facing the devil on his territory.

The hardest revelation to get over to us is this: if we can fathom what laying treasures up in heaven means, if we can become reward-minded about what we are accomplishing eternally, then it releases God to work in our lives now.

That is why Jesus said:

Seek ye first the kingdom of God, and his righteousness; and all these things shall be added unto you.

The Lord began to deal with me: "Get a revelation of heaven into them. Work on their fear, because if you work on their fear, you are working on the access the devil has in their lives."

That is why He said:

Humble yourselves therefore under the mighty hand of God, that he may exalt you in due time:

Casting all your care upon him; for he careth for you.

Be sober, be vigilant; because your adversary the devil, as a roaring lion, walketh about, seeking whom he may devour:

Whom resist stedfast in the faith.

Part of humbling myself and part of exaltation is getting rid of care, because care is what makes me devourable. It is what the devil uses to seek me out and devour me. To get rid of care is to resist the devil.

No wonder Jesus said you will be recompensed at the resurrection of the just.

Go to Matthew 6:31:

Therefore take no thought, saying, What shall we eat? or, What shall we drink? or, Wherewithal shall we be clothed?

For after all these things do the Gentiles seek: for your heavenly Father knoweth that ye have need of all these things.

But seek ye first the kingdom of God, and his righteousness; and all these things shall be added unto you.

What things? The things the Gentiles seek after between birth and the grave. Some Gentiles can have quite an appetite for things.

Think of the Arab family that had a buyer, not for oil fields, but for the wives. He flew to New York in a flying palace with all his wives and a buyer. The fuel bill alone was seventeen thousand five hundred dollars to fly across the ocean. Can you imagine paying a fuel bill like that and then having your wife present you with the shopping bill?

The Gentiles have quite an appetite. But Jesus says you do not have to be concerned about these things. You do not have to take a thought for them. Seek first the kingdom of God and His righteousness, and all these things will be added to you.

Notice it says His righteousness. He is not talking about seeking the righteousness that I have been made by faith. That righteousness is not of works; it is not of yourselves, lest any man should boast. It is the gift of God.

By faith I was made the righteousness of God in Christ. That is enough to get me to heaven. I did not earn it, merit it, or deserve it. I believed for it. I cannot boast that I earned my own salvation, because that righteousness is the free gift of God.

So He cannot be talking about seeking the righteousness that purchased my entrance to heaven. I am going to heaven. This message is not designed to bring you under condemnation. The harder we preach on the rewards of heaven, the more I am trying to teach you to put an eternal weight on your life instead of judging and gauging everything only to the end of this one.

The righteousness He tells us to seek first is not the righteousness I received when I was born again. Even if I never do another thing for God, even if I go to church once a month and sit there while the rest of my life is consumed by the flesh, the pride of life, and everything I can accomplish in this world, I am still going to heaven. I was born again by the blood of Jesus. It is not of works, lest anyone should boast.

So what righteousness is He telling us to seek?

His righteousness. Jesus' right standing in the kingdom.

He says, "All the Gentiles seek after standing through wealth, things, and pride. But you are supposed to seek after My standing. Seek My right standing, and the things the Gentiles seek after will be added to you."

What standing is He talking about? What right standing am I supposed to seek that causes those things to be added to me?

We do not have to leave the chapter, because Matthew 6 deals with seeking God in the condition of the heart through fasting, praying, and giving. The stipulation was this: do not fast, pray, or give to be seen by men. If you fast, pray, or give to be seen by men, you have your reward.

But if you enter secretly and fast, pray, and give to be seen by God alone, then He who sees in secret will reward you openly.

Seek first the kingdom of God and His righteousness. How do I seek that standing? Through fasting, praying, and giving with the right heart. My Father, who sees in secret, will reward me openly. Part of that open reward is that all these things shall be added to me.

Why is there no revival? Because we consume our energy operating in the natural, seeking after things and contending after things until we burn our whole life up.

"I got caught up in this care, that care, this worry, and that worry."

Until they consumed you.

The devil brings persecutions, afflictions, and cares to get you out of seeking the kingdom first. How do you seek the kingdom first? Through fasting, praying, and giving secretly, so God who sees in secret rewards openly.

When persecutions, cares, and afflictions hit, what do we usually give up first? Praying, fasting, and giving. Giving often goes first. With fasting, for many people there is not much to give up because they do not do much of it.

The devil brings external pressures designed to force you to stop seeking the kingdom and His right standing. When you stop seeking the kingdom, the devil comes in and says, "Now You do not have any right to add things to them, because they are in fear, torment, and worry."

He pulls his greatest switch. He gets us to quit seeking the kingdom and laying treasures up in heaven so he can whip us here. But if he cannot get you to stop laying treasures up in heaven, then he cannot whip you here.

Matthew 6:19 says:

Lay not up for yourselves treasures upon earth, where moth and rust doth corrupt, and where thieves break through and steal:

But lay up for yourselves treasures in heaven, where neither moth nor rust doth corrupt, and where thieves do not break through nor steal:

For where your treasure is, there will your heart be also.

All my life I used those verses in offerings, and there is truth in that. But if there is anything I want you to do, it is prosper in God. The thought of operating in the flesh makes me sick anymore. I cannot stomach it.

In times past, like everyone else, I quoted that verse and equated giving with laying up treasures in heaven. In truth, giving is one-third of what this verse is talking about.

If the treasure we lay up in heaven is the eternal things worked in people's lives because of our giving, then your treasure is not laid up in heaven until the offering you sow works something eternal in the kingdom.

Scripture says that if you bid Godspeed to a man preaching another gospel, you are a partaker of his evil deeds just for saying, "Godspeed." How much more if you support the man? Then you have his reward.

Giving is important, and God knows whether I gave with the right heart. But if you have a revelation of giving, you should also have a revelation of the ground you are sowing into.

Any farmer knows you do not sow barley and wheat on a highway. If I have two fields, one rocky and one rich and fertile, I am not going to sow the rocky field. That would be foolish. I would get half the harvest. I am going to sow the rich field, because it will bring forth more treasure when it produces.

You are sitting here with all this revelation knowledge. Listen to me: you do not lay treasure up in heaven until the money you have sown works something eternal in people's lives, such as training for ministry, the born-again experience, healing, the indwelling of the Holy Ghost, or the perfecting of God in them so they produce in the kingdom.

If you sow into a dead work, you will get a dead harvest.

Your treasure is not laid up until a man gets born again through your money, a man gets trained through your money, or something eternal is worked in people.

These are the power triplets: fasting, praying, and giving.

Every time you fast and pray and release authority, and the devil says, "I cannot hang on anymore," and he looses a group of people, revival comes, and they are born again--those people are treasures laid up in heaven on your account because you fasted in secret and He rewarded you openly.

Every time you lock yourself in this room over the next year, praying seven hours a day, and suddenly the strong man's fingernails scrape across the dam because he cannot hold it back anymore, and he turns loose, the dam breaks, the flood comes, the Holy Ghost washes over, revival is born, and people are swept into the kingdom--whether it is a thousand a Sunday or five thousand a Sunday--because you prayed in secret and your Father saw in secret, He releases authority and rewards openly.

If through your prayers people are born again, He is the one keeping track. They are the treasure laid up in heaven.

When I give to a devil-stomping, mountain-moving ministry, and that ministry goes out, gets people born again, trains them, and launches them, then if I support that ministry, every eternal thing worked in people's lives is laid up in heaven on my account.

Where your treasure is, there will your heart be also.

Where is your treasure? Is it on this earth? Is it in temporary things? Is it in what you can gain out of this life? Is it in making a name for yourself?

Where is your heart?

Or is it placed in heaven, with every person you can pray, give, and fast into the kingdom? Your Father who sees in secret rewards openly. If you work what is next to His heart, He will work what is next to your heart.

If you seek the kingdom first and His righteousness, He will add everything you need. You do not have to worry. You do not have to be in fear.

The devil wants you to stop laying treasures up in heaven.

Jesus said that when you invite people to a meal, do not invite your rich neighbors and kinsmen, because the motivation of your heart is, "I did for them because they will do for me." That motivation is self-exaltation.

But invite the poor, the halt, the maimed, the lame, and the blind. Your greatest reward will come at the resurrection of the just.

The sower sows the Word, and Satan comes immediately to steal the Word sown in their hearts.

What does he bring to steal it? Persecutions, afflictions, the cares of this life, the deceitfulness of riches, and the lusts of other things.

He knows that if he can steal the Word of God out of you through persecution and affliction, he can get you to quit seeking the kingdom first and His righteousness. If he can get you to stop doing that, it will not be possible for God to continue adding to you.

Go back to Luke 14.

The devil is definitely afraid of you binding together and laying treasures up in heaven. He is afraid because it will loose God to add to you in this temporary realm, while you are working the closest thing to God's heart in the eternal realm.

Many times I have thought of the day when I run into Jesus in heaven, that glorified Man standing there. I will know Him by His eyes.

You have to remember, He is the second Person of the Godhead. He is Logos. He may be a glorified Man, but He is as much God as He is man. All things were made by Him, and without Him was not anything made that was made.

Here I am face to face with a glorified Man. Before He became a man, He was in another form of God. But He took on the form of humanity, and He will wear that body for the rest of time, which of course has no end.

God so loved the world that He gave Jesus, His only begotten Son. The more I walk around in that love, the more strength it gives me. The more that foundation of peace comes, the more I say, "Come on, devil, pour it out. We are going to make it through. We are going to see revival come."

This Man loved me so much. God loved me so much that He gave Jesus.

I am a treasure to Him. I have trouble fathoming that love. I am such a rare treasure to Him that He chose to take my form, man, and spend eternity with me as a glorified Man: me glorified, He glorified.

Scripture says we are equal with Jesus in His humanity; He did not consider equality with God robbery. But when you look that glorified Man in the eyes, remember that He is as much God as He ever was. You are equal with Him in His humanity, but you are not equal with Him in His deity. The planet you are standing on was made by Him when He was known as the Logos.